Introduction

India and China comprise nearly forty per cent of the world's population. Their relationship is vital for three billion people. It is also consequential for the countries in their neighbourhood and for the world at large. After the war of 1962, the two countries had managed to preserve a high degree of military stability along the Himalayan border. Then, in June 2020, a melee at Galwan in Ladakh left Indian and Chinese soldiers dead and injured. Both sides rushed military reinforcements to the area. Despite a series of negotiations, they were unable to disengage the nearly fifty thousand troops amassed on either side of the border – as many troops as they had deployed in the entire 1962 war. Six decades of relative calm between the two countries collapsed in a matter of weeks. The Ladakh crisis suggests that India–China relations are darker and more complex than most observers appreciate or acknowledge. It is tempting to ascribe the current difficulties between them to the memory of the war and to the unsettled border. Clearly, those do affect Delhi's and Beijing's thinking. Yet Galwan suggests that we need to dig deeper. Why did these two societies become locked into a conflict that has stubbornly refused to go away?

Post-imperial India and China started well. India was one of the first countries to recognize the communist government and support its right to a seat in the United Nations. From 1950 to 1953, Delhi mediated between Beijing and Washington during the Korean war. Jawaharlal Nehru, who would go on to be India's first prime minister, had twice visited China before India gained its independence and had helped arrange for a group of Indian medical personnel to go there in the late 1930s. In *The Discovery of India*, he recorded his admiration for Chinese society that continued after rising tensions in the 1950s: 'the vitality of the Chinese people astonishes